Topic 9 — Gupta Age

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Origin · Chandragupta I · Samudragupta · Chandragupta II · Kumaragupta I · Skandagupta · Gupta Administration · Gupta Administration System · Gupta Inscriptions · Gupta Coins · Gupta Gold Coins · Gupta Achievements · Prayag Prashasti · Allahabad Pillar Inscription · Nalanda University · Gupta Art · Gupta Literature · Gupta Science · Gupta–Vakataka · Economy & Society

Sources baked in: Prayag Prashasti, Mehrauli, Bhitari, Eran, Mandasor, Fa-Hien, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — 2022 silver coins, 2018 south-king match, 2025 Kalidasa, 2024 Fa-Hien order, economy & society traps **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Gupta Age

Book–writer pairs | literature + science | later pairs kept for 2025-style stems

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Abhijnanashakuntalam (अभिज्ञानशाकुन्तलम्), *Malavikagnimitra* (मालविकाग्निमित्रम्), *Vikramorvashiyam* (विक्रमोर्वशीयम्)	**Kalidasa** (कालिदास)	Gupta dramas (नाटक); CG II court tradition
Raghuvamsa (रघुवंश), *Kumarasambhava* (कुमारसंभव)	**Kalidasa** (कालिदास)	Mahakavyas (महाकाव्य)
Meghaduta (मेघदूत), *Ritusamhara* (ऋतुसंहार)	**Kalidasa** (कालिदास)	Lyrics (गीतिकाव्य)
Shringara Shataka (शृंगार शतक)	**Bhartrihari** (भर्तृहरि)	Not Kalidasa
Amarakosha (अमरकोश)	**Amarasimha** (अमरसिंह)	Lexicon; Navaratna name
Mrichchhakatika (मृच्छकटिकम्)	**Sudraka** (शूद्रक)	Charudatta (चारुदत्त)–Vasantasena (वसन्तसेना)
Mudrarakshasa (मुद्राराक्षस), *Devichandraguptam* (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्)	**Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त)	Chanakya play; Ramagupta story
Kamasutra (कामसूत्र)	**Vatsyayana** (वात्स्यायन)	Gupta-age Sanskrit treatise
Panchatantra (पंचतंत्र)	**Vishnu Sharma** (विष्णु शर्मा) (tradition)	Fable cycle
Kiratarjuniya (किरातार्जुनीय)	**Bharavi** (भारवि)	Late Gupta / after
Aryabhatiya (आर्यभटीय)	**Aryabhata** (आर्यभट)	499 CE; maths / astronomy

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Panchasiddhantika (पंचसिद्धांतिका), *Brihatsamhita* (बृहत्संहिता)	**Varahamihira** (वराहमिहिर)	Astronomy / encyclopaedia
Brahmasphutasiddhanta (ब्रह्मस्फुटसिद्धान्त)	**Brahmagupta** (ब्रह्मगुप्त)	Early 7th c. edge of the age
Setubandha (सेतुबन्ध) (*Ravanavaho* (रावणवहो))	**Pravarasena II** (प्रवरसेन द्वितीय)	Vakataka Prakrit
Prayag Prashasti (प्रयाग प्रशस्ति)	**Harishena** (हरिषेण)	Samudragupta's literary eulogy
Nala Champu (नल चम्पू)	**Trivikrama Bhatta** (त्रिविक्रम भट्ट)	Later match pair
Kathasaritsagara (कथासरित्सागर)	**Somadeva** (सोमदेव)	Later match pair
Gita Govinda (गीत गोविंद)	**Jayadeva** (जयदेव)	Later match pair
Brihatkathamanjari (बृहत्कथामंजरी)	**Kshemendra** (क्षेमेन्द्र)	Later match pair

- **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) is not the author of *Shringara Shataka* (शृंगार शतक) (**Bhartrihari** (भर्तृहरि)).
- *Mudrarakshasa* (मुद्राराक्षस) is Vishakhadatta's (विशाखदत्त) play. It is not the *Arthashastra* (अर्थशास्त्र).

> **Logic:** Full Navaratna / science teaching stays in the Gupta Literature cards.

9.1 Origin of the Guptas

~320–550 CE | Magadha / Pataliputra | after the Kushans | not a Mauryan house

- Founder-memory is **Sri Gupta**, about **275 CE** in coaching chronology. His title is **Maharaja**, not Maharajadhiraja.
- I-tsing later remembers a Sri Gupta shrine for Chinese pilgrims.
- Next is **Ghatotkacha**. He is still **Maharaja**. He is father of Chandragupta I.
- The imperial clock starts with **Chandragupta I**.
- The default home is **Magadha** (मगध). The capital is **Pataliputra**.
- They are **not** Mauryas. Chandragupta I is not Chandragupta Maurya.
- Sources are inscriptions, coins, Puranas, and Fa-Hien. Campaign meat is the Prayag Prashasti.
- Gupta **samvat** is often pegged at **319–320 CE**, Chandragupta I's accession in most coaching notes.
- The line to learn is Sri Gupta, then Ghatotkacha, then Chandragupta I, then Samudragupta, then Chandragupta II, then Kumaragupta I, then Skandagupta.

> **Logic:** Sri Gupta and Ghatotkacha are **Maharaja**. The imperial title starts with **Chandragupta I**.

9.2 Chandragupta I

First Maharajadhiraja | ~319–335 CE | Lichchhavi marriage

- He is the son of Ghatotkacha and the first Gupta to take **Maharajadhiraja**.
- He marries Lichchhavi princess **Kumaradevi**. That match is the political lift. It brings Vaishali / Lichchhavi prestige.
- The **king-and-queen** gold type is this pair. It is not Chandragupta II.
- Prayag later calls Samudragupta the **Lichchhavi-dauhitra**, daughter's son of the Lichchhavis.
- Gupta era **319/320 CE** is usually tied to his accession. The capital is **Pataliputra**. His son and successor is **Samudragupta**.

> **Logic:** King-queen gold is not Chandragupta II's Shaka silver.

9.3 Samudragupta's Military Campaigns

Son of Chandragupta I | ~335–375 CE | digvijaya | source = Prayag Prashasti

Samudragupta's wars are remembered as a **digvijaya**. The main source is the **Prayag / Allahabad Prashasti** of court poet **Harishena**.

Who he is

- Accession follows Chandragupta I.
- Titled **Sarva-raj-ochchetta** ("uprooter of all kings" — only Gupta ruler with this title) and **Kaviraja**; coins depict him in **Veenavadana** (lute-playing) stance.
- King **Meghavarna** of Sri Lanka sent an embassy to Samudragupta requesting permission to build a Buddhist monastery for pilgrims at Bodh Gaya.
- He is called *Lichchhavi-dauhitra* (daughter's son of the Lichchhavis) on the Allahabad shaft, because mother **Kumaradevi** was a Lichchhavi princess.
- **V. A. Smith** in *The Early History of India* called him the **Napoleon of India** for his campaigns.
- The poet-king pose is *kaviraja*. The **lyrist / veena** gold type backs that.
- He performs ashvamedha after the wars. A horse type appears on gold.
- Chinese memory says Sri Lankan king **Meghavarman** sought his leave to build a Buddhist monastery at **Bodh Gaya**.

Digvijaya — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Samudragupta aimed to make the Guptas the paramount power of Aryavarta and to force southern and frontier kings into tribute.

Course: The Prashasti groups the wars by region and policy. - In **Aryavarta (north)** nine kings are **uprooted**. Their land is annexed. - In **Dakshinapatha (south)** twelve kings are defeated and restored under the technical policy of **ग्रहण-मोक्ष-अनुग्रह (Grahana-Moksha-Anugraha)**: - *Grahana* = capturing the southern kings - *Moksha* = liberating them - *Anugraha* = reinstating them as tributary feudatories upon

payment of tribute (*sarva-karadana*). *(Contrast: In Aryavarta/North India, he followed प्रसभोद्धरण (Prasabhoddharana) = violent extermination / direct annexation).* - Forest **atavika** chiefs are brought to heel. - Frontier states and **ganarajyas** pay tribute. Not all are wiped out.

Result: Magadha becomes the clear north Indian paramount power. Southern kings keep their thrones but accept Gupta overlordship. The prashasti boasts he never lost — treat that as court praise. His son and successor is **Chandragupta II**.

South kings often matched

King	Kingdom
Dhananjaya (धनंजय)	**Kusthalapura**
Nilaraja	**Avamukta**
Ugrasena (उग्रसेन)	**Palaka / Palakka**
Vishnugopa	**Kanchi**

- Other south names papers may add include Mahendra of Kosala, **Vyaghraraja** of Mahakantara, **Hastivarman** of Vengi, **Svamidatta** of Kottura, **Damana** of Erandapalla, and **Kubera** of Devarashtra.

North, frontier, and gana tribute

- North names in the uprooted set include Ganapatinaga, **Nagasena** (नागसेन), **Achyuta**, **Chandravarman**, and **Balavarman**.
- Frontier tribute includes Samatata, **Davaka**, **Kamarupa**, **Nepala**, and **Karttripura**.
- Ganarajya tribute includes Malava, **Yaudheya**, **Arjunayana**, and **Madraka**.

> **Logic:** South = **tribute and restore**. North = **uproot**. Vishnugopa ≠ a Magadha king.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q87]:** Allahabad Prasasti (Prayag) of Samudragupta identifies contemporary kings: Dhananjaya = Kusthalapur; Nilraja = Avamukta; Damana = Erandapalla; Vishnugopa = Kanchi. *(See Q4 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

9.4 Chandragupta II

Son of Samudragupta | ~375–415 CE | Vikramaditya | Sakari | Devagupta

- He ends the **Western Kshatrapas** in Malwa–Gujarat by defeating last Saka king **Rudrasimha III**.
- He takes the title **Sakari** (destroyer of the Sakas).
- **Ujjain** becomes a second pole. **Pataliputra** stays the old capital.
- The **Mehrauli Iron Pillar Inscription** (Delhi) records that King *Chandra* defeated a confederacy of enemies in **Vangas** (Bengal) and crossed the seven mouths of the Indus to conquer the **Vahlukas** (Bactria).

- Sanchi and Vakataka records also name him **Devagupta**, **Devraja**, and **Devashri**.
- He marries Naga princess **Kuberanaga**.
- Queen **Dhruvadevi** is mother of **Kumaragupta I**.
- Daughter **Prabhavatigupta** marries Vakataka **Rudrasena II**. She later rules as regent.
- Later play tradition (*Devichandraguptam* of Vishakhadatta) says he killed elder brother **Ramagupta** and married Dhruvadevi. Treat that as literary memory, not a hard inscription spine.
- **Udayagiri** in Madhya Pradesh has Varaha / Vishnu caves.
- The **Mehrauli iron pillar** names **Chandra**. Most books take this as this king.
- The pillar is a **Vishnu dhvaja** set up on a hill called **Vishnupada**.
- It now stands in the courtyard of Quwwat-ul-Islam near the Qutub Minar.
- Navaratna court is a later legend. **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) is the name papers keep. Full nine-name table sits in the literature card.
- After the Shaka victory he issues **silver rupaka** coins.
- The strongest Shaka-victory proof in the 2022 paper is those **silver coins** weighing about **33 grains**.
- **Fa-Hien (Faxian)** was in India **399–414 CE** during this reign to collect authentic Buddhist Vinaya texts.
- **Crucial UPPCS Trap:** In his entire travelogue (*Fo-Kwo-Ki / Record of Buddhist Kingdoms*), **Fa-Hien NEVER mentions the name of Emperor Chandragupta II or his royal court**, despite praising the peace, absence of capital punishment, and prosperity of the Middle Kingdom (Madhyadesha).
- Noted that **cowrie shells (कौड़ी)** were used by common people as the daily medium of exchange for small purchases, while gold dinaras and silver rupakas were used for large/state transactions.
- In traveller chronology he comes **before** Hiuen Tsang, I-Tsing, and Al-Biruni.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q23]:** Chandragupta II Vikramaditya was the first Gupta ruler to issue **silver coins (Rupaka)** after conquering the Western Sakas (Rudrasimha III). *(See Q5 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q149]:** Chronology of foreign travellers: Megasthenes (c. 302 BCE) → Faxian/Fa-Hien (c. 399–414 CE) → Xuanzang/Hiuen Tsang (c. 629–645 CE) → Yijing/I-Tsing (c. 671–695 CE). *(See Q3 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Chandragupta **II** ≠ Chandragupta **I**. Chandragupta **II** ≠ Chandragupta **Maurya** (मौर्य).

9.5 Kumaragupta I

Son of Chandragupta II and Dhruvadevi | ~415–455 CE | Mahendraditya | Nalanda patron

- Takes the title **Mahendraditya** (महेन्द्रादित्य). Performs **ashvamedha**. Horse and peacock types appear on his gold.
- Tradition remembers him as founder-patron of the **Nalanda** mahavihara; Chinese sources use the name *Shakraditya* for that patronage memory.
- The **Dashpur / Mandasor** silk-weavers' inscription sits in his age. Local governor **Bandhuvarman** is named. The silk **shreni** from the Lata region built a **Sun** temple and later repaired it. Coaching often

calls this the earliest Indian “advertisement” style guild record. Composer tradition names **Vatsabhatti**, not Bhavabhuti.

- Pushyamitra / other frontier trouble starts near the end of the reign. Son and successor: **Skandagupta**.

> **Logic:** Nalanda founder-patron = **Kumaragupta I**, not Fa-Hien and not Xuanzang.

9.6 Skandagupta

Last great imperial Gupta | ~455–467 CE | Huna war | Bhitari (Ghazipur, UP)

Skandagupta is the last strong imperial Gupta. His reign is remembered for holding the **Hunas** and repairing **Sudarsana** lake.

Huna war — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: After Kumaragupta I, Huna pressure rose on the northwest and on the Gupta frontier. The empire needed a military answer.

Course: Skandagupta fought the Hunas and checked the first major raid. The **Bhitari** pillar at Saidpur tehsil, **Ghazipur**, Uttar Pradesh, is the war record.

Result: The first Huna raid is stopped for a time. After his death the pressure returns and helps thin the empire. The full sequel — **Toramana**, **Mihirakula**, **Yashodharman** — sits in the Post-Gupta chapter.

Other Skandagupta facts

- He is the son of Kumaragupta I.
- The **Junagadh / Girnar** inscription records repair of the **Sudarsana** lake (after the older Rudradaman repair).
- Titles include **Vikramaditya** (विक्रमादित्य) / **Kramaditya** (क्रमादित्य) on some coin types.
- After him the centre thins. Later names remembered in coaching lists include Purugupta, Buddhagupta, and Narasimhagupta Baladitya.
- The imperial Gupta clock ends about the 6th century. The next political reunion in the north is **Harsha**.

> **Logic:** Bhitari = **Skandagupta vs Hunas**. Not Samudragupta’s south march.

9.7 Gupta Administration

Decentralised empire | samanta plus land grants | lighter centre than the Mauryas

The Gupta state is **not** a Mauryan-style spy-and-adhyaksha machine. Power is shared with **samantas** and with land grants.

King and ministers

- The king is **Maharajadhiraja** and **Paramabhattaraka**.
- Divine kingship is louder than in the Mauryan file.
- A **mantriparishad** advises. The final word is the king's.
- The **sandhivigrahika** is the peace-and-war / foreign minister.

Feudatories and grants

- A **samanta** (सामंत) is a feudatory. He sends tribute and troops. He is not a Mauryan salaried amatya.
- **Brahmadeya / agrahara** grants punch holes in the crown's direct take.
- Guptas donate heavily to temples and Brahmins.
- The state is less central than the Mauryas.

Dues and labour

- Land revenue appears as **bhaga** and **udranga**, remembered as about **one-sixth** of produce on royal land.
- Irrigation dues appear as **udakabhoga**.
- Border / fringe cultivator dues appear as **uparnika** in some lists.
- Forced labour **vishti** is treated as a state take, not wage labour.

Guilds and law books

- Guilds (**shreni**) keep their own wages, standards, prices, and internal justice.
- The guild head runs the body without daily royal micromanagement.
- Smriti age names include **Yajnavalkya** and **Narada**.
- The **Vayu Purana does not** give a Gupta admin manual. That claim is **false**.
- The Vishnu Purana *does* carry Maurya names.

> **Logic:** "Guptas more central than Mauryas" is the trap.

9.8 Gupta Administration System

- **Master Land Classifications: Kshetra** (cultivated land), **Khila** (waste/fallow land), **Aprahata** (jungle/forest land), **Vasti** (habitable land), **Gapata-Sarah** (pasture land).
- **Revenue & Taxes: Bhaga** (king's 1/6th customary share), **Bhoga** (daily gift of fruits/flowers), **Kara** (periodic tax), **Bali** (customary offering), **Udranga** (water tax / fixed land tax), **Uparikara** (extra tax on temporary tenants), **Vishti** (forced unpaid labour).

Ladder of units | officers named on copper plates

Level	Unit	Officer
Empire		Maharajadhiraja

Level	Unit	Officer
Province	**Bhukti**	**Uparika**
District	**Vishaya**	**Kumaramatya** / **Ayuktaka**
Sub-district	**Vithi**	local notables / *vithi-mahattara*
Village	**Grama**	**Gramika** / *ashtakuladhikarana*

- Correct sequence: **Bhukti** → **Vishaya** → **Vithi** → **Grama**.
- **Kumaramatya** = all-purpose district executive. Damodarpur plates name him.
- **Ayuktaka** = appointed district officer. Same band as kumaramatya.
- **Pustapala** = record-keeper of grants.
- **Dutaka** = carries the grant / royal order.
- Army still **chaturanga** (fourfold: infantry, cavalry, elephants, chariots). The board game **chess** is remembered as growing from this *chaturanga* idea in the Gupta age and later travelling west through Iran.
- Village elders settle petty cases. King is the last court.
- No Arthashastra-style spy book as the Gupta headline.

> **Logic:** Bhukti ≠ Vishaya. Do not skip **Vithi** in the ladder.

9.9 Gupta Inscriptions

Stone + copper plates | names, grants, wars

Record	Ruler	Fact
Prayag Prashasti	Samudragupta	Harishena. Campaigns in 9.3
Allahabad pillar (इलाहाबाद स्तंभ)	(the shaft)	Ashoka + prashasti in 9.14
Mehrauli iron pillar	Chandra = CG II in most keys	Rust-resistant iron
Bhitari pillar	**Skandagupta**	**Huna** war; Ghazipur, UP
Udayagiri	CG II / Kumaragupta	Vaishnava caves
Eran	Samudragupta / later Buddhagupta–Bhanugupta	Varaha; **sati** of Goparaja's widow (~510 CE)
Damodarpur plates	Later imperial Guptas	Kumaramatya. Land grants
Mandasor / Dashpur	Kumaragupta age / silk weavers	Sun temple; Bandhuvarman. Yashodharman's later Huna boast is a different Mandasor text

- Copper plates = *tamrapatra* land grants.

- **Ishanavarman**–Haraha / Sarvavarman–Gaya pairs are **Maukhari / later Gupta**, not this imperial set. Gaya plate is still Samudragupta.

> **Logic:** Bhitari = Skandagupta vs Hunas. Not Samudragupta's south march.

9.10 Gupta Coins

Gold + silver + copper | 2022 lives on the silver | Bayana hoard

- Gold **dinara** = prestige (types in 9.11).
- **Silver rupaka** = Chandragupta II after the Shaka war. **~33 grains**.
- Copper for the market.
- Legends in **Sanskrit**. Lakshmi / Garuda common on the reverse.
- The largest remembered Gupta gold find is the **Bayana** hoard in Bharatpur, Rajasthan. Gupta coins also turn up across UP, Bihar, Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Odisha.
- Kushan gold already ran in the NW. Gupta gold is the later "classical" portrait set.

> **Logic:** 2022 does **not** treat gold as the Shaka-victory proof.

9.11 Gupta Gold Coins

Type → king match-list | Samudragupta's six famous types

Type	Usual king
King and queen (Kumaradevi)	**Chandragupta I**
Ashvamedha horse	**Samudragupta**
Lyrist / veena	**Samudragupta**
Battle-axe / *parashu*	**Samudragupta**
Tiger-slayer (*vyaghra*)	**Samudragupta**
Standard / Garuda types	**Samudragupta** (in the famous six-type set)
Archer	**Chandragupta II** (commonest)
Chhatra / lion-slayer	**Chandragupta II**
Lion-slayer / peacock	**Kumaragupta I**
King fighting lion	**Skandagupta**

- Coaching remembers about **six** famous gold types under **Samudragupta** (Garuda, archer variants, battle-axe, ashvamedha, tiger, lyrist / veena). Do not dump every later subtype into that six.

- Standard is often near **120–144 grains** for **gold**. Silver *rupaka* is about **33 grains**.

> **Logic:** Lyrist = Samudragupta. Archer = CG II. King-queen = CG I.

9.12 Gupta Achievements

“Golden age” = culture + gold + relative peace. Not a perfect welfare state.

- First stable pan-north empire after the Kushans.
- Sanskrit court culture. Temple stone and brick.
- Science names in 9.18. Art in 9.16. Nalanda in 9.15. Economy and society in **9.23**.
- Fa-Hien’s mild Gangetic picture is this age. It is not a census.
- Skandagupta holds the Hunas for a time. After him the centre thins.
- End ~6th c. Huna pressure + samanta drift. Harsha is the next north reunion, not a Gupta.
- Six orthodox darshanas (Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Mimamsa, Vedanta) and Charvaka sit in the Religious Movements chapter — do not dump them here as Gupta inventions.

> **Logic:** Golden age ≠ “no samantas, no decline.”

9.13 Prayag Prashasti

Harishena | eulogy of Samudragupta | carved on the Allahabad shaft

- Court poet **Harishena**. Also a *sandhivigrahika* in some readings.
- Lists the four-fold campaign policy: north **uprooted**, south **restored** as tribute, forest chiefs, frontier / ganarajya tribute.
- 2018 south four on this text: Dhananjaya–Kusthalapura, Nilaraja–Avamukta, Ugrasena–Palaka, Vishnugopa–**Kanchi**.
- Calls the king a *kaviraja* and a warrior. Lyrist coins back the poet-king pose.
- Praise text. Not a campaign diary with dates.
- *Devichandraguptam* (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्) is **Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त), not Harishena (हरिषेण).

> **Logic:** Prashasti = the **words**. The **shaft** they sit on is the Allahabad / Prayag pillar.

9.14 Allahabad Pillar Inscription

One shaft, four inscription layers

- Stone is **Mauryan** (Chunar polish). Originally from **Kaushambi** (कौशांबी). Later moved to Allahabad / Prayagraj (Akbar tradition).

- Layer 1: **Ashokan** edicts in Brahmi.
- Layer 2: Queen's edict on the charity of Ashoka's wife **Karuvaki** (Mauryan detail; full card in the Mauryan chapter).
- Layer 3: Gupta layer = Harishena's **Prayag Prashasti** of Samudragupta in Sanskrit / Brahmi.
- Layer 4: **Jahangir** (जहाँगीर) later wrote on it in Persian. Birbal's name also appears in later memory of the shaft.

> **Logic:** The pillar is not "only Gupta." It is Ashoka's shaft reused.

9.15 Nalanda University

Mahavihara | Bihar | Gupta start, later boom | ancient universities home

- Tradition places the founding of **Nalanda** under **Kumaragupta I** in the 5th century CE. Chinese sources call him **Shakraditya**.
- The site seal reads *Sri Nalanda mahavihariyarya-bhikshu-sanghasya*.
- Subjects included Buddhist philosophy, grammar, logic, and medicine. It became the greatest Buddhist university of ancient India.
- **Hiuen Tsang** (ह्वेनसांग) studies here during **Harsha's** reign. **I-tsing** visits later. Both are **visitors**, not founders.
- Later **Pala** rulers patronise Nalanda. Destruction by **Bakhtiyar Khalji** is medieval, not Gupta.

Other ancient universities — key facts

- **Takshashila (Taxila)** is the older northwest teaching town in Gandhara. **Chanakya** (चाणक्य), **Panini** (पाणिनि), and **Jivaka** belong to its tradition. It is **not** a Gupta foundation.
- **Vikramashila** in the Bhagalpur belt is a **Pala** foundation under **Dharmapala**. It peaks after Nalanda's Gupta start.
- **Vallabhi** in Gujarat is a **Maitraka** centre of learning. The **Svetambara Jain canon** council is linked to Vallabhi. Vallabhi is **not** Vaishali.

University	Region	Founder / patron fact
Takshashila	Gandhara	Pre-Mauryan teaching town; Panini grammar
Nalanda	Bihar	**Kumaragupta I** founder-patron
Vikramashila	Bengal–Bihar belt	**Pala Dharmapala**
Vallabhi	Gujarat	**Maitraka**; Jain Svetambara council

> **Logic:** Founder-patron fact = **Kumaragupta I** for Nalanda. Xuanzang ≠ Fa-Hien. Vallabhi ≠ Vaishali.

9.16 Gupta Art

Sarnath school | Hindu stone temples begin

- The **Sarnath Buddha** has a plain robe, downcast eyes, and a halo. It is India's "classical" Buddha.
- It is not the Kushan **Gandhara** Greco-Buddhist drape. Sarnath is the Gupta plain robe.
- The **Udayagiri Varaha** belongs to Chandragupta II.
- The **Deogarh** Dashavatara temple (UP/MP belt) is an early stone *shikhara* (शिखर).
- **Bhitargaon** in the Kanpur belt of Uttar Pradesh is a brick temple.
- **Eran** has a Varaha and pillars.
- **Tigawa** in Madhya Pradesh is a flat-roof shrine.
- Ajanta's famous painted caves are largely **Vakataka** (Deccan allies), with Gupta-age style links.
- The Mehrauli iron pillar is rust-resistant iron. "Chandra" on it is usually **Chandragupta II**.

> **Logic:** Sarnath is Gupta. Gandhara is Kushan. Ajanta is not the default Gupta fact.

9.17 Gupta Literature

Kalidasa is the Gupta fact | 2025 also dumps later author–book pairs

- **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) belongs to the Chandragupta II (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय) tradition.
- The play *Abhijnanashakuntalam* (अभिज्ञानशाकुन्तलम्) is his drama of Dushyanta and Shakuntala.
- The play *Malavikagnimitra* (मालविकाग्निमित्रम्) is his drama of Shunga king Agnimitra and Malavika.
- The play *Vikramorvashiyam* (विक्रमोर्वशीयम्) is his drama of Pururavas and Urvashi.
- The mahakavya *Raghuvamsa* (रघुवंश) is his epic of Raghu's line.
- The mahakavya *Kumarasambhava* (कुमारसंभव) is his epic of the birth of Kartikeya.
- The lyric *Meghaduta* (मेघदूत) is his cloud-messenger poem.
- The lyric *Ritusamhara* (ऋतुसंहार) is his cycle of the six seasons.
- *Shringara Shataka* (शृंगार शतक) is **Bhartrihari** (भर्तृहरि), not Kalidasa.

Navaratnas (later tradition)

Coaching lists **nine gems** at Vikramaditya / Chandragupta II's court. Historians treat the full nine as a **later legend** (*Jyotirvidabharana* (ज्योतिर्विदाभरण)). Papers still ask the names. **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) is the firm Gupta fact.

Gem	Field
Kalidasa (कालिदास)	Poetry and drama
Amarasimha (अमरसिंह)	*Amarakosha* (अमरकोश) (lexicon)
Varahamihira (वराहमिहिर)	Astronomy (*Panchasiddhantika* (पंचसिद्धांतिका), *Brihatsamhita* (बृहत्संहिता)) — actually **6th century**

Gem	Field
Dhanvantari (धन्वंतरि)	Medicine
Vararuchi (वररुचि)	Grammar
Ghatakarpara (घटकर्पर)	Poetry
Kshapanaka (क्षपणक)	Astrology
Shanku (शंकु)	Architecture
Vetala Bhatta (वेताल भट्ट)	Magic / counsel

- **Sudraka** (शूद्रक) wrote *Mrichchhakatika* (मृच्छकटिकम्) (*The Little Clay Cart*). It is the urban love story of merchant **Charudatta** (चारुदत्त) and courtesan **Vasantasena** (वसन्तसेना), and it also mirrors city administration and society in a Gupta-age Ujjain setting.
- **Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त) wrote *Mudrarakshasa* (मुद्राराक्षस), a Chanakya play of Gupta date, and *Devichandraguptam* (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्) (Ramagupta story).
- **Amarasimha** (अमरसिंह) wrote the *Amarakosha* (अमरकोश).
- **Vatsyayana** (वात्स्यायन) wrote the *Kamasutra* (कामसूत्र). It belongs to the Gupta-age Sanskrit milieu, not to Kalidasa's seven works.
- **Vishnu Sharma** (विष्णु शर्मा) is the traditional author of the *Panchatantra* (पंचतंत्र).
- **Bharavi** (भारवि) wrote *Kiratarjuniya* (किरातार्जुनीय), late Gupta or after.
- **Harishena** (हरिषेण) belongs to the Samudragupta (समुद्रगुप्त) court. He composed the *Prayag Prashasti* (प्रयाग प्रशस्ति).
- Trap: **Dhanvantari** (धन्वंतरि) is the Navaratna Ayurveda name. **Bhaskara II** (भास्कर द्वितीय) (*Lilavati* (लीलावती), *Siddhanta Shiromani* (सिद्धांत शिरोमणि)) belongs to the **12th century**, not Chandragupta II's court.

Writer	Book
Trivikrama Bhatta (त्रिविक्रम भट्ट)	**Nala Champu** (नल चम्पू)
Somadeva (सोमदेव)	**Kathasaritsagara** (कथासरित्सागर)
Jayadeva (जयदेव)	**Gita Govinda** (गीत गोविंद)
Kshemendra (क्षेमेन्द्र)	**Brihatkathamanjari** (बृहत्कथामंजरी)

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q48]:** *Janakiharana* was authored by **Kumaradasa** of Sri Lanka, NOT by Kalidasa (author of Meghaduta, Raghuvamsha, Kumarasambhava, etc.). *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q86]:** Works and authors: Mrichhakatikam = Shudraka; Mudrarakshasa = Vishakhadatta; Harshacharita = Banabhatta; Dashakumaracharita = Dandin. *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

> **Logic:** Jayadeva, Somadeva, and Kshemendra are **later** than the Gupta court. Kalidasa belongs to **Chandragupta II**.

9.18 Gupta Science

Astronomy + maths + iron

- **Aryabhata** (आर्यभट) wrote the *Aryabhatiya* (आर्यभटीय) in **499 CE**. Tradition places him at Kusumapura / Pataliputra. He teaches that the earth rotates and explains eclipses without demon stories. Sine, cosine, and inverse-sine ideas appear in the *Aryabhatiya* and *Surya Siddhanta* (सूर्य सिद्धांत) horizon of the 5th century.
- **Varahamihira** (वराहमिहिर) wrote the *Panchasiddhantika* (पंचसिद्धांतिका) and the *Brihatsamhita* (बृहत्संहिता). He sits at Ujjain.
- **Brahmagupta** (ब्रह्मगुप्त) wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* (ब्रह्मस्फुटसिद्धान्त) in the early 7th century, at the edge of this age. He describes cyclic quadrilaterals and zero rules.
- Medicine circulates in *Sushruta* (सुश्रुत) and *Charaka* (चरक) redactions. **Sushruta** (सुश्रुत) is far earlier than the Gupta court — do not make him a Gupta contemporary. **Dhanvantari** (धन्वंतरि) is the Navaratna medicine name for this age.
- The Mehrauli pillar is rust-resistant iron. “Chandra” on it is usually **Chandragupta II**. Decimal place-value is in use. “Aryabhata invented zero” is too crude for a sharp true/false. He uses place value.

> **Logic:** Aryabhata is not Varahamihira. Fa-Hien did not write the *Aryabhatiya*. *Lilavati* is not Gupta.

9.19 Gupta Decline — Cause, Course, Result

~455–550 CE | Hunas + samantas + urban thinning

Cause: Repeated **Huna** pressure after Skandagupta, growing **land grants** that shrank direct revenue, rising **samanta** feudatories, and loss of western silver zones weakened the Gupta centre.

Course: Skandagupta holds at **Bhitari**. Later rulers shrink the Magadha core. **Toramana** and **Mihirakula** press from the northwest. **Narasimhagupta Baladitya** is remembered checking Mihirakula. Many earlier valley towns thin; by Xuanzang’s day **Pataliputra** looks village-like. Mathura and other old centres also show decline layers.

Result: No stable pan-north emperor remains after about **550 CE**. **Harsha** (606) reunites the upper Gangetic core only for a time.

9.20 Fa-Hien (Faxian) — Gupta-age Chinese Traveller

~399–414 CE | Chandragupta II | *Fo Guo Ji*

- Fa-Hien’s purpose is to collect **Vinaya** (विनयपिटक -) texts, not to hunt Mahayana sutras (that later aim belongs to Xuanzang).

- His route runs Central Asia → Pataliputra → Mathura → **Tamralipti**. He does **not** describe **Nalanda** as a famous campus (Nalanda's founder-patron is Kumaragupta I).
- He remembers **cowries** in routine market use and a free **hospital / charity house at Pataliputra** endowed by citizens.
- His book is the ***Fo Guo Ji***. Chronology places him **before** Hiuen Tsang, I-tsing, and Al-Biruni.

9.21 Ancient Universities — Full Four-Way Card

University	Region	Patron / age	Subjects & facts	End / trap
Takshashila (Taxila)	Gandhara (NW)	Pre-Mauryan; **Chanakya**, **Panini**	Grammar, medicine, politics	Damaged by **Hunas** (~5th c.)
Nalanda	Bihar	**Kumaragupta I**; Pala peak	Buddhist philosophy, logic; Xuanzang studied here	**Bakhtiyar Khalji** ~1193
Vikramashila	Bhagalpur belt	**Pala Dharmapala** (~8th c.)	Mahayana, Tantra; **Atisa** taught here	Destroyed ~12th c.
Vallabhi	Gujarat	**Maitraka** rulers	Brahmanical + Jain; **Svetambara Jain council** (~5th c.)	Not Vaishali; not Buddhist 2nd council

> **Logic:** Founder four-way = Taxila (pre-Mauryan) | Nalanda (Kumaragupta I) | Vikramashila (Dharmapala) | Vallabhi (Maitraka).

9.22 Gupta–Vakataka Alliance

Marriage diplomacy | Deccan partner | not a Gupta province

- Founder of the Vakataka house is **Vindhyashakti**.
- **Pravarasena I** is the first real empire-builder. He takes the title **Samrat**, performs **four ashvamedhas**, and stretches influence from Bundelkhand toward the Deccan.
- **Pravarasena II** of the same house composed the Prakrit *Setubandha* (*Ravanavaho*).
- Chandragupta II's daughter **Prabhavatigupta** married Vakataka **Rudrasena II** and ruled as **regent** after his death — Gupta influence in the Deccan without direct annexation.
- **Udayagiri** caves overlap Gupta court culture; **Ajanta** (अजंता) later phases are often **Vakataka**, not "pure Gupta court."

9.23 Gupta Economy and Society

Ports, textiles, guilds, language, women

- East sea door for north Indian trade is **Tamralipti** (Bengal), linking Southeast Asia, China, Lanka, Java, and Sumatra.

- West sea door is **Bhrigukachchha (Bharuch)** for western trade. Other names in the wider Gupta trade map include Arikamedu, Kaveripattinam, Muziris, Pratishthana, and Sopara.
- After Roman–western disruption, Indian merchants lean more on **Southeast Asian** routes across the Bay of Bengal. Monsoon winds make that cruise practical.
- Textile manufacture is a prime industry. Gujarat, Bengal, Deccan, and Tamil country are famous cloth zones. **Dashpur / Mandasor** silk weavers are the inscription fact.
- Land measures in grants include **kulyavapa** and **dronavapa**. Uncultivated forest-type land can appear as **aprahat**.
- In Sanskrit dramas of the age, elite men speak **Sanskrit**; women and Shudras often speak **Prakrit**.
- Women's status is not equal with men in this age. First inscriptional **sati** memory is **Eran ~510 CE** (widow of commander **Goparaja**).
- Vaishya caravan / guild heads appear as **sarthavaha** (सार्थवाह). Guild law is *samaya / shreni-dharma*.

> **Logic:** Tamralipti ≠ Broach. Eran sati ≠ Junagadh lake. *Lilavati* ≠ Gupta.

UP Focus

Fact	Place
Allahabad / Prayag pillar	Prayagraj — Ashoka + Karuvaki + Harishena + Jahangir
Bhitari Huna pillar	**Ghazipur**, UP — Skandagupta
Bhitargaon brick temple	Kanpur belt
Sarnath Gupta Buddha	Varanasi
Kaushambi origin of the Allahabad shaft	Kaushambi
Fa-Hien's Ganga plain	includes the UP stretch of the empire
Eran sati / Varaha	Madhya Pradesh (not UP) — still a must-score inscription